

GA-CM-02

Gifts & Hospitality from Families

Clear boundaries for receiving tokens of appreciation without creating obligation, influence, or unequal treatment.

APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

AUTHORITY

Gardner Culture and management standard

01 Purpose

Families may sometimes wish to thank staff. This policy protects warm school relationships while preventing gifts, money, or hospitality from creating obligation, favouritism, influence, or the appearance of a conflict of interest.

02 Modest tokens of appreciation

A staff member may accept an occasional, modest token such as a card, flowers, a small food item, or a low-value classroom gift when it is freely given, appropriate to the relationship, and could not reasonably influence a professional decision. Acceptance never changes how a learner or family is treated.

03 Gifts that must not be accepted

Staff must not accept:

- Cash, loans, or personal financial assistance.
- Cash equivalents, vouchers, or gift cards unless management has approved a specific school-wide arrangement in writing.
- A gift of significant or uncertain value.
- Travel, accommodation, private entertainment, or substantial hospitality.
- A gift connected to admissions, assessment, placement, discipline, procurement, a complaint, or another pending decision.
- A secret gift or anything offered in exchange for special access, information, treatment, or influence.

04 No solicitation

Staff may not request, suggest, pressure, or organise personal gifts, collections, discounts, loans, services, or contributions from learners or families. School-approved fundraising and staff-appreciation activities must use authorised processes.

05 Declaration and decision

When the value, intention, or appropriateness of a gift is uncertain, the staff member must disclose it promptly and must not use, spend, or dispose of it until a decision is received. The employee must follow the written direction to decline, return, share, surrender, use, or record the gift.

06 Hospitality and professional boundaries

Refreshments offered during an ordinary school-related meeting or community event may be accepted when reasonable and incidental. Personal invitations, repeated hospitality, private business arrangements, or benefits that may blur professional boundaries require prior management approval.

07 Respectful refusal and records

Decline an unsuitable gift warmly and explain that Gardner policy protects fairness for every child and family. Employees must complete the required declaration or gifts-register entry when a gift is more than a modest token or a potential conflict exists.